



2012

The Google Summer of Code Programme

A large number of college students with engineering backgrounds seek summer internships, but finding amazing projects to work on for just two to three months is daunting. Even the best students find it really hard to seize an intern position that allows them to work on something challenging, ship production code that will have an impact, and make a decent sum of money. If you are a student looking for such an opportunity, the Google Summer of Code (GSoc) programme is your ultimate path to glory. Read on!

As Google puts it, “The Google Summer of Code is a global programme that offers students stipends (US\$ 5000 as of 2012) to write code for open source projects.” Open source organisations provide help and mentor students that work under them from around the world, under this programme.

The initiative began in the year 2005, when Larry Page, one of the co-founders of Google, noticed that most computer science students were not doing computer-science-related work over the summers. The idea was to “...make students flip bits, not burgers.” As contributing to open source projects can be an overwhelming experience for young people, GSoc provides a great platform and relevant industry experience to students with real-life projects. The official GSoc homepage (referred to as Melange) is: <http://www.google-melange.com/>.

GSoc statistics

GNU, KDE, the Python Foundation, the Linux Foundation, Drupal, Git, Apache and Mozilla are among some of the popular names that participate in this programme. Due to the huge number of participating organisations, you can be working on kernel development, computer graphics, visualisation, game design, compilers, Web applications, or even bioinformatics! It is up to the students to choose their area of expertise or something they're passionate about.

This year (2012), a total of 6685 applications were received from 4258 students in 98 countries by 180 selected mentor organisations. A total of 1212 proposals from 69 countries were

selected. India contributed the largest number of students, a total of 227. For detailed statistics on the programme, visit Google's open source blog at <http://google-opensource.blogspot.in/>.

How does the programme work?

The programme has a strict timeline, which every mentor organisation and student needs to follow. However, the precise dates change every year. You can always refer to the ‘Events and Timeline’ on the GSoc home page.

The major events (relevant for student applications) are:

1. Announcement of the programme for the year (January end or early February).
2. Application deadline of mentor organisations (around March 9 to 11). Before any student applications can begin, Google chooses the organisations that will be participating for the year. Usually, a large fraction of the previous year's organisations make it in, though there are a few changes every year. Some new names may come up, while a few old ones are skipped.
3. The list of accepted organisations gets published on the SoC website (around March 20). This is the time students should start to look out for organisations that they find interesting. Every organisation has its own ideas page, usually in a wiki. Students can either propose their own ideas, or work on what is listed. With the large number of project ideas, it might take a while before you're sure where to apply. A good idea is to start contacting mentors early, introducing yourself and getting to know the community. A student is allowed to submit multiple proposals.